

In the Big League

Sujoy Roy kicked his high profile job as an investment banker with JP Morgan to turn a professional gamer and... is still making as much money!



Advent of death-matching and multi-player games has turned gaming into a competitive arena where 'cyberathletes' turn passion into a profession. Professional gamers (pro-gamers) are making money out of death matching and see it getting better. Sujoy Roy, MA, MSc, who was working at JP Morgan in New York, quit his job as a high flying investment banker and became a pro-gamer.

A veteran Quaker from UK, the plunge into full-time professional gaming has clicked well for him. Though he didn't achieve the kind of success or notoriety that *Fatality* or *Makaveli* would have, his business skills have gone a long way in making him the 'Anandtech' of pro-gaming.

His site, xsreality.com is an E-Sports community site that garners a huge following among pro-gamers. The site posts news, strategies and recorded demos of pro-gaming tournaments. We had a few words with him.

How would you introduce yourself? Sujoy Roy, PhD - Professional Gaming?

I'm no longer a pro-gamer officially. My main business is with a new company called Virtual Gaming Alliance (VGA) which promotes E-Sports through offline gaming centres around the UK. My official title there is: Sujoy Roy, MA, MSc Cantab - Marketing Director. But who uses the official title anyway?

And how many hours do you play each day?

Work with VGA generally takes up my whole day. However, I spend an hour or two in the evening playing games online.

Which games are hot right now, and where do you see professional gaming in the next few years?

Counter-Strike is hot. It's unfortunate that no other game has been able to break the *Counter-Strike* dominance in online gaming. We're due for something new and exciting that will change the face of E-Sports, but I'm not sure what it will be. Maybe *Quake IV*, *DOOM III*, *Unreal Tournament II*... we'll have to wait and see.

Will pro-gaming gain mass acceptance and become as big as Soccer or Basketball?

Someday, yes. But not today or within the next few years. Pro-gaming has a long way to go still in developing the structure of a real sport. Right now I'm building a league in the UK based on regional locations at registered gaming centres so that the teams represent a real town and a real community of people. When leagues like this gain acceptance we can begin to start taking on real sports.

Your comments on the LAN party culture.

I'm more interested in actual gaming centres than LAN parties. I see a gaming centre as a social club for gamers, which they can visit daily.

Cheating has become a huge issue and is strangling the integrity of online games. Is there a one-stop solution for this?

There is no easy solution to cheating. But the most obvious one is for more games to take place in controlled setups such as live tournaments and gaming centres.

What do you think about the deathmatch demo between (TUA) Wile and (DS) Peter? (TUA is India's number 1 gaming clan.)

I guess that the players in India have been playing in a somewhat closed environment and have not learned from the European and American players yet. I'm afraid the only way to describe the play—and I'm really trying not to sound conceited here—is that it's very bad.

Tips for budding Indian pro-gamers.

The important skills to master as a pro-gamer are not physical ones like accuracy and reaction times. Understand your opponent so that you can be one step ahead in your strategy. 

Based on an e-mail interview conducted by Sriram Sharma

// Gamers in India play in a closed environment and have not learned from their European and American counterparts //